2.2 Women and the War

Think of a time when you stepped up and took on a role you'd never shouldered before. You might have felt uncomfortable about assuming the role, but—like women during the Civil War—you probably felt that you had to do it.

MAIN IDEA Women took an active role in the Civil War, both on the battlefield and at home.

WOMEN ON THE BATTLEFIELD

Just as they had in the American Revolution, women during the Civil War took on roles that brought them closer to the field of battle. Many women, in particular, became nurses. Before the war, society considered it inappropriate for women to care for injured and ill men. The Civil War quickly changed all that. Soon, most nurses were women, and at least one woman, **Mary Edwards Walker**, became a doctor.

In the North, Dorothea Dix and a **philanthropist** named **Clara Barton** led the nursing effort. A philanthropist is someone who actively promotes human welfare. Already known for her work on behalf of the mentally ill, Dix led volunteer nurses in a march on Washington in April 1861, demanding that women be allowed to help the Union forces. As a result, the Secretary of War gave Dix the responsibility of recruiting female nurses. Dix insisted that her volunteers be no younger than 30 years old. More than 2,000 women volunteered. For her part, Barton collected and delivered medical supplies, clothing, and food for Union soldiers throughout the war. She aided wounded Union soldiers and the Confederate prisoners they captured.

In the South, a young woman named **Sally Tompkins** led the effort to provide nursing care through her private hospital in Richmond, which she supported with her own personal fortune. The hospital treated more than 1,300 soldiers during the four years it was open, and it returned more men to the battlefield than any other hospital. In addition, more than 600 nuns from 12 different Catholic religious communities also served as nurses during the war and attended to both Union and Confederate soldiers.



The founder of the American Red Cross, Clara Barton was 29 years old when this photo was taken (1850). A former teacher, Barton was working as a clerk at the U.S. Patent Office in Washington, D.C., when the Civil War began. Determined to support the war effort, she set out to help the soldiers, some of whom were once her students. Soon, Barton was following the Union Army to the battlefields, where she tended to the wounded and dying.

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CRITICAL VIEWING A nurse feeds a wounded Union soldier in a hospital in Pennsylvania in 1861. How would you describe the conditions in the hospital?

WOMEN AT HOME

While some women helped on the battlefield, many more did their part at home. When war came, women all over the country took over the roles of their husbands, brothers, and sons in order to keep family farms and businesses running. On small farms, women and children took charge of raising animals and planting, tending, harvesting, and selling crops. On southern plantations, women directed the overseers and enslaved people. In the cities, women took jobs in factories and offices, replacing the men who had left to fight. Many women also volunteered to raise food and money, make clothing, and provide medical supplies for the troops and their communities.

Even for those women who stayed at home, the war sometimes came uncomfortably close. **Civilians**, or people not in the military, who lived near the battlefields had to deal with the sounds and dangers of battle. They could only watch as enemy combatants marched through their towns and raided their homes for supplies. To add to the stress, a family's only means of communicating with husbands and sons at war was through letters. Since troops were constantly on the move, delivering mail to them was difficult. If a soldier was killed or missing in action, the bad news arrived by letter. And since soldiers carried no official identification, many families were not informed at all. If a loved one's letters stopped coming, his family had to assume that he was not coming home.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did Dorothea Dix open up the occupation of nursing to women?
2. **SUMMARIZE** What new roles did women play during the Civil War?
3. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** How did the war impact women, combatants, and civilians in different ways?

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